WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

ANTIGUA AND BARBUDA

Americas

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
St John's and Antigua Cruise Port	Capital and commercial centre; the cruise port, run by Global Ports Holding under a 30-year concession, opened a new terminal in January 2026 alongside a fifth berth for the largest cruise ships	Cruise tourism, retail, real estate, port services
V.C. Bird International Airport	Main air gateway, with terminal upgrades under way and new 2026 routes to the Dominican Republic, Guadeloupe and Lagos	Aviation services, logistics, hospitality
Antigua resort coastline	Hotel pipeline including Moon Gate Hotel & Spa (2026), a 114-room Marriott and a Nikki Beach resort with 127 residences (2029)	Luxury hotels, branded residences, hospitality services
English Harbour and Falmouth (south coast)	Antigua's established yachting and sailing centre, anchoring the island's high-end marine tourism	Marinas, yacht services, boutique hospitality
Barbuda	Sister island opening up to premium tourism, with the new Burton-Nibbs International Airport, Nobu Beach Inn due in 2026 and Rosewood Barbuda slated for 2028	Ultra-luxury tourism, resilient energy, eco-tourism
Five Islands	Home to the University of the West Indies Five Islands campus, which the 2026 Budget identifies for expansion	Education, student housing, health and technology services
Special Economic Zone, Barnacle Point	1,600-acre zone with its own customs and immigration controls and broad tax and duty exemptions under a 2025 statutory instrument; around $200 million has been invested to date	Light manufacturing, mixed-use development, hospitality

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Antigua and Barbuda Investment Authority (ABIA), established under the Investment Authority Act 2006, provides facilitation on licences and permits and processes duty and tax concessions for qualifying projects
- Tourism and Business Special Incentives Act 2013 and small-business legislation offering duty, tax and customs relief for qualifying hotel, tourism and enterprise investments

- Special Economic Zone Act 2015, providing for zones with dedicated customs regimes and exemptions from income, corporate and import duties
- Citizenship by Investment Programme, with routes from a $230,000 National Development Fund contribution, $300,000 in approved real estate or $1.5 million in business investment, now with a 30-day physical residency requirement and regional regulatory oversight
- Public-private partnerships for infrastructure, as demonstrated by the 30-year cruise port concession with Global Ports Holding
- Eastern Caribbean dollar under the Eastern Caribbean Central Bank, held at a fixed peg to the US dollar and backed by reserves of 97.6% of demand liabilities

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Antigua and Barbuda in October 2026 offers a stable, tourism-led economy with improving public finances and strong investor appetite. The IMF estimates real GDP growth of 3.0% in 2025 and projects 2.8% in 2026, while the government's 2026 Budget targets 5%. Inflation fell to an estimated 1.2% in 2025 from 6.2% in 2024, and public debt has dropped from 101% of GDP in 2020 to 68.3% in 2025, supported by a primary surplus of 4.9% of GDP, with the regional 60% target in view before 2035. Foreign direct investment reached about $282 million in 2025, or 12.4% of GDP, taking the inward FDI stock to $2.9 billion. Stayover arrivals rose 6.7% in the first quarter of 2026, with March the highest month on record, and a new cruise terminal, airport upgrades and the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting in November 2026 add momentum. The Antigua and Barbuda Labour Party's re-election in April 2026, with 15 of 17 seats, gives clear policy continuity.

The country's main structural consideration is its reliance on tourism, which generates receipts of around 45% of GDP, and on Citizenship by Investment inflows, which reached 2.6% of GDP in 2025. Since 1 January 2026, US restrictions on new visitor, student and immigrant visas for Antiguan nationals, linked by Washington to Citizenship by Investment, have added a policy dimension, although visas issued before that date remain valid. The government has responded constructively: introducing a 30-day physical residency requirement, cooperating with US authorities on biometrics, joining a new five-country regional Citizenship by Investment regulator and seeking a formal review. Exposure to hurricanes is managed through adaptation investment estimated at around 1.6% of GDP a year and access to climate finance, including a $20 million Green Climate Fund resilience programme. This creates opportunities in diversified tourism, resilient infrastructure and renewable energy, where the country's 86% renewable electricity target (conditional on international support) points to substantial investment demand.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
US visa restrictions linked to Citizenship by Investment	Since January 2026, new US visitor, student and immigrant visas for Antiguan nationals have been suspended, with a visa bond programme also applied; previously issued visas remain valid	The government has tightened residency rules, expanded biometric cooperation and requested a US review; investors relying on Antiguan nationals' US travel should plan around current visa rules
Concentration in tourism	Tourism receipts are equivalent to around 45% of GDP, so performance tracks visitor demand in the US, UK and Europe	Record early-2026 arrivals, new airlift and the cruise expansion support demand, while diversification creates openings in education, the blue economy and technology
Hurricane and climate exposure	As a small island state, Antigua and Barbuda faces regular hurricane risk, with adaptation needs estimated at around 1.6% of GDP a year	Build to resilient standards and insure appropriately; climate-finance programmes create co-investment opportunities in resilient buildings and energy
Legacy arrears	External arrears to Paris Club creditors of around 7% of GDP and domestic arrears remain to be cleared	The government is validating domestic arrears and pursuing a liability management operation; falling debt ratios and a Fiscal Resilience Oversight Committee support the trend
External balance	The current account deficit widened to 11.6% of GDP in 2025, reflecting construction-related imports	The deficit is largely financed by FDI, and the regional currency is backed by ample reserves; projects with local-currency

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
		revenue face no exchange-rate mismatch against the US dollar peg
Imported energy costs	Electricity relies largely on imported fuel, so oil price movements feed into costs and inflation	The 86% renewable electricity target opens opportunities in solar, storage and grid resilience, building on projects in Barbuda
Small market and project delivery capacity	A population of around 100,000 and construction-sector capacity constraints can slow large projects, and some earlier flagship schemes have progressed more slowly than first announced	Conduct thorough partner and project due diligence, phase developments realistically and use ABIA support on approvals

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Antigua and Barbuda's risk profile is that of a well-established, investor-friendly small island economy with improving fundamentals. Public debt has fallen by around a third of GDP since 2020, inflation is low, the banking sector reports non-performing loans of 3.4% and capital adequacy of 21.2%, and the Eastern Caribbean dollar's long-standing peg provides currency stability. The main considerations are the US visa restrictions linked to Citizenship by Investment, which the government is addressing through tighter residency rules, biometric cooperation and a new regional regulator, and the concentration of activity in tourism and exposure to hurricanes common to the Caribbean. These are mitigated by strong tourism demand, FDI-financed investment, climate-finance partnerships and a clear political mandate following the April 2026 election. Investors should monitor the US review of visa measures, build climate resilience into project design and plan for clearance of legacy arrears, while taking confidence from the country's track record of attracting high-end tourism investment.

MARKET ACCESS

Antigua and Barbuda is a member of CARICOM and of the Organisation of Eastern Caribbean States, whose Economic Union provides for free movement of goods, people and capital across member states, and of the Eastern Caribbean Currency Union. It has been a WTO member since 1995 and, through CARIFORUM, has Economic Partnership Agreements with the EU and the UK, which give duty-free, quota-free access for goods exports. UK–Antigua trade totalled £175 million in 2025, up 8% on 2024. Tourism is the main export: the US accounts for 46% of stayover visitors, Europe 34% and Canada 12%. Connectivity is expanding through new regional and African air links, the new Burton-Nibbs International Airport on Barbuda and a growing cruise schedule, with almost 895,000 cruise passengers forecast for 2026.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Gaston Browne)	The Prime Minister, also Minister of Finance, began a fourth term in May 2026 and leads economic, investment and Citizenship by Investment policy	Primary reference point for strategic direction and major project approvals
Antigua and Barbuda Investment Authority (ABIA)	National investment promotion agency processing licences, permits and concessions	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentives
Eastern Caribbean Central Bank (ECCB)	Regional monetary authority managing the US dollar peg and supervising licensed banks across the currency union	Relevant for currency, banking and payments matters
Ministry of Tourism and Antigua and Barbuda Tourism Authority	Lead the country's largest sector, airlift development and destination marketing	Key counterparts for hotel, airline and tourism-services investment
Citizenship by Investment Unit and regional CBI Regulatory Authority	Administer and oversee the programme that channels investment into approved real estate and the National Development Fund	Essential for developers of CBI-approved projects and for compliance assurance

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Financial Services Regulatory Commission (FSRC)	Regulates non-bank financial institutions, insurers, credit unions and international banks	Relevant for financial-services licensing and structuring
Antigua Public Utilities Authority (APUA)	State utility for electricity, water and telecommunications, central to grid and resilience projects	Key counterpart for renewable energy and utility investment

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Commonwealth Business Forum, organised by the Commonwealth Enterprise and Investment Council with the government on 2–4 November 2026 during the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting, offers a timely platform for meeting ministers and investors around resilience, the blue economy, technology, finance and sustainable tourism. The Antigua and Barbuda Chamber of Commerce and Industry and the Antigua and Barbuda Hotels and Tourism Association provide local business liaison, and the High Commission in London supports UK-based investors. The Caribbean Development Bank, which administers UK Caribbean Infrastructure Fund grants, the Green Climate Fund and the UAE–Caribbean Renewable Energy Partnership Fund are active in infrastructure and resilience financing.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Antigua and Barbuda is best suited to hospitality and luxury real-estate investors, including branded-resort and residence developers drawn to Antigua's coastline and Barbuda's emerging ultra-premium market; marine and yachting businesses; renewable energy and resilient-infrastructure investors aligned with the 86% renewable electricity target and climate-finance programmes; and education, health and technology investors supporting diversification. Developers of Citizenship by Investment-approved projects benefit from a strengthened regulatory framework, and should build current US visa policy and full due diligence into their planning.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage ABIA on incentives and approvals
Open dialogue with the Antigua and Barbuda Investment Authority to confirm eligibility for concessions under the investment and tourism incentives legislation.

STEP 2: Attend the Commonwealth Business Forum in November 2026
Use CHOGM week in Antigua to meet ministers, agencies and co-investors and to explore partnership opportunities.

STEP 3: Build climate resilience into project design
Apply hurricane-resilient standards and insurance from the outset, and explore co-financing with the Caribbean Development Bank and climate funds.

STEP 4: Track US visa policy and the CBI regulatory framework
Monitor the US review of visa measures and the new regional regulator, and take specialist advice where projects depend on Citizenship by Investment funding.

STEP 5: Target tourism-linked and renewable energy opportunities
Focus on hotels, cruise and airport-related services and solar and storage projects, where demand and government support are strongest.